Evaluation models, global diversity and DH

Afanador, María José
MJ.Afanador28@uniandes.edu.co
Universidad de los Andes, Colombia

Arriaga, Eduard
EArriaga@clarku.edu
Clark University, USA

Galina Russell, Isabel
igalina@unam.mx
UNAM, Mexico

Priani, Ernesto
epriani@gmail.com
UNAM, Mexico

Spence, Paul Joseph
paul.spence@kcl.ac.uk
King's College London, United Kingdom

Steyn, Juan
Juan.Steyn@nwu.ac.za
South African Centre for Digital Language Resources, South Africa

Evaluation has been, and continues to be, a major challenge for the digital humanities at various levels (Schreibman / Mandell / Olsen 2011, Galina 2012). University administrators often welcome the inter/trans-disciplinary nature of DH and its promise of digitally mediated innovation, but institutional and national scholarly evaluation systems are still heavily predicated on print-era models and tend to perform poorly when assessing outputs which are non-traditional in conception or format. This is not a challenge unique to DH of course – it forms part of a wider reappraisal of the changing norms and structures of twenty-first century scholarship in light of a series of digitally mediated transformations in how we create and engage with knowledge and culture – but DH has in some senses served as a laboratory for exploring new challenges in research assessment.

Debates about evaluation are closely bound up with discussions about the future of digital humanities (and digital scholarship in the humanities more broadly), and are important in various areas which determine professional development, including recruitment, promotion, peer review of research publications, scholarly profiles, teaching and project funding. It is no surprise then that digital humanists have been at the forefront of attempts to create stable evaluation mechanisms – for evaluating digital work/projects (Rockwell 2012), digital outputs in general (Ciula 2025, Smithies 2002) or specific output genres such as digital editions (Sahle 2014) – and have collaborated on wider frameworks for evaluating digital scholarship (MLA 2014). Such guidelines may both serve as new benchmarking systems for assessing scholarship on a practical level and as agents of transformation in wider academic policy (e.g. in promoting critical digital literacies), in a context of wider debate about diversity in research roles and contributions, and attempts to reform research assessment (CoARA). But there is still much work to do in engaging with evaluation from the perspective of global and linguistic diversity in DH.

DH evaluation guidelines are rarely explicit about their intended geographic domain of influence, but like all tools, they are not culturally neutral, and both their authorship and their intended audience tend to be geoculturally situated, even (or perhaps especially) when they are written in English. For this reason, one crucial development has been the crafting of guidelines for DH evaluation in languages other than English as part of attempts by emerging DH communities to engage with their local context, define local practice and forge their own identities (Red de Humanidades Digitales - RedHD, Humanidades Digitales Hispánicas - HDH, Red Colombiana de Humanidades Digitales - RCHD).

Authors such as Risam & Gil (2022) and Ortega (2019) remind us how DH and digital scholarship are productions defined by local contexts. When working towards shared or a common framework for DH evaluation guidelines, contextual sensitivity should not be lost.

This paper, through insights gathered from various DH communities across the globe, reflects on the different cultures of evaluation that exist. From establishing new evaluation guidelines in Southern Africa and Colombia to refining established guidelines such as those of the MLA and RedHD, we will shed light on the multiple facets of DH evaluation in the regions represented by the studied guidelines and the important role that evaluation can play in informing pedagogy and generating conversation towards strengthening international diversity in the field.

Cultures of innovation

The paper opens by looking broadly at the different cultures of evaluation that exist, where in

a study conducted by Spence, respondents from more than 17 countries have consistently highlighted two contradictory dynamics – the local nature of evaluation (national accreditation bodies, epistemic vernaculars or local cultures of evaluation) versus the benefits and disadvantages of having cross-regional or 'global' systems of assessment.

Despite the important advances in global and multilingual responses to anglophone bias science in recent years (Balula, A. et al. 2021), more work needs to be done to study global and multilingual dynamics in DH, and to understand the incentives and barriers which affect how knowledge is produced in different regional conditions. The tensions between calls for flexibility and stability in evaluation, between highly computational and 'minimal' modes in DH research and 'major-minor' language dynamics will be highlighted throughout the paper.

Emerging contexts

The contrasts noted are especially visible in areas where DH as a discipline is still emerging and developing. In the South African context special interventions such as the South African Research Infrastructure Roadmap allowed for the establishment of the South African Centre for Digital Language Resources with a special mandate towards enabling the uptake of DH given the transformative role that it can play within the humanities. In such an emerging context there is a need to balance the gradual introduction of new methodologies towards stimulating growth in an upcoming field and at the same time to still adhere to good methodological standards.

Moving to the Colombian context, with the birth of the Colombian Network of Digital Humanities in 2016 and the MA program in Digital Humanities at Universidad de los Andes, 2017, the discussion of evaluation models started to outline the need to evaluate digital projects as scholarly outputs. The model for evaluation that was developed and approved at the Universidad de los Andes to validate the production in Digital Humanities, emerged in a context in which there are few incentives to engage in digital scholarship and the national scientific institution has not incorporated digital humanities as a research area. The criteria are now utilised for evaluating digital humanistic products, as part of faculty promotion criteria, and as guidelines for developing DH projects. The challenges towards establishing the criteria as well as the dimensions considered for evaluation will be shared.

Refining and strengthening existing guidelines

Moving from emerging contexts, the paper will then further focus on the important role that established evaluation guidelines can contribute to strengthening DH in the global context. First the guidelines for Evaluating Digital Scholarship produced by the MLA and then those published by RedHD.

The MLA Guidelines were originally published in 2000, revised in 2012, and again updated in 2024 to address the changing state of digital scholarship produced in institutions of research and higher education in the fields of language, literature and culture locally and globally.

Despite the globalizing tendencies of digital technology and higher education, the assessment of digital scholarship must be mindful of contextual elements. In that sense, the guidelines developed by the MLA —as a US-based association— cannot and shouldn't be seen as a model to be uncritically adopted by institutions in other geographical and cultural contexts. However, it is important to underscore that the guidelines can be a mechanism to open channels of communication not only between individuals, institutions and organizations but also between diverse linguistic traditions taught and adapted to the US and Canadian contexts. In that sense, the guidelines must be seen as a model that can be used to generate a continuous cross-cultural conversation to assess projects that include cross-cultural elements. It should foster transparency, constant communication of concepts and objectives, fairness and constant reflection on the way this set of fields and practices produce knowledge and engage other disciplines.

Moving from evaluation to strengthening pedagogy

During the 2009 foundational workshops that led to the creation of the Red de Humanidades Digitales (RedHD), three key priorities were identified, one of which was the urgent need for a document to evaluate digital projects (Galina et al. 2012). This led to the first publication, in 2013, of the "Guía de buenas prácticas para la elaboración y evaluación de proyectos de Humanidades Digitales" , a set of guidelines with an accompanying checklist. Similar to how the MLA guidelines where refined and developed further, the Guía was also updated in 2020, in conjunction with the publication of a book *Pautas para el desarrollo y*

evaluación de proyectos digitales en las humanidades, providing a theoretical and conceptual framework for the Guía.

From the outset, the Guía was designed as both an evaluative and didactic resource for digital project development. After its 2020 revision, the focus shifted more strongly toward its instructional role. Insights will be shared in how these guidelines over time helped to strengthen and shape the cohesive identity of DH in the region and how such guiding documents also evolved in tandem with both RedHD and the field of digital humanities in Mexico.

Closing

This paper brings together and reflects on a series of global studies and landmark guidelines for evaluation in DH. It examines questions around the role of evaluation, its aims, design, intended audience, thematic coverage, professional scope, actual impact and future projection. Through the process of comparing and contrasting different global perspectives on scholarly assessment in DH, the paper will conclude with some proposals on how DH research evaluation mechanisms can be designed with multilingualism and geoculturally inclusive values at their core; can actively seek to aid transferability across geographic and professional domains, all while respecting local frames of reference.

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